

Berkeley Neighbors for Housing & Climate Action 2024 Candidate Questionnaire

Candidate Name: Shoshana O'Keefe

District / Office being sought: Berkeley City Council District 5

1. Berkeley's Housing Element lays out the city's plan for new housing construction through 2031, ensuring the city can meet its Regional Housing Needs Allocation (RHNA) of ~9,000 homes across a range of income levels.

The Housing Element commits Berkeley to a number of major policy changes in order to meet state requirements for affirmatively furthering fair housing, including citywide zoning for "missing middle" housing, a San Pablo Specific Plan, an updated Demolition Ordinance, and upzoning along North Shattuck, Solano, and College Ave, among other items.

What is your view on the Housing Element and these policies? What are the most important things we need to do to implement the City's Housing Element?

I am in favor of all upzoning plans that are mentioned, and I would like to add a wish to upzone University Ave. west of MLK, since it is well served by transit, especially the portion close to North Berkeley BART.

I am strongly in favor of the missing middle housing initiative, although I have concerns about adding additional density in the fire zone. I struggled with this position a lot because I am so in favor of added density and adding it in an equitable way, but after consulting heavily with the Berkeley Fire Fighters, I've become convinced that the public safety risk of additional density in the fire zone is too high.

Please discuss your ideas and priorities around:

- a. Missing Middle housing
- b. San Pablo specific plan
- c. Zoning for housing in high-resource neighborhoods like North Shattuck, Solano, and College Ave

Missing middle - answered above

San Pablo specific plan - This is a much needed process that I support. San Pablo has always been an overlooked part of our city that nonetheless hosts many small businesses and has potential for huge economic opportunity as more housing is added to the corridor. I would like to look for ways to increase pedestrian safety and promote walkability as a way to help the business community and promote a sense of community and vibrancy.

Zoning for high resource neighborhoods - Absolutely. It's a good idea, and is especially important to pursue for equity reasons. We need to consult the fire department as there may be

specific issues brought by the narrowness of the streets, and of course the smaller lot sizes make it more challenging, but I have no objection at all (the opposite, actually) to allowing greater density in these areas.

2. Berkeley's Climate Action Plan sets forth a goal of 80% reduction in greenhouse gas (GHG) emissions by 2050. Today, the two major sources of GHG emissions in Berkeley are from gas-powered automobiles and natural gas used in buildings.

Berkeley has a variety of plans and programs intended to help address these emissions, including the Electric Mobility Roadmap and the Berkeley Existing Building Electrification Strategy. Other related efforts include the Bicycle Plan and Pedestrian Master Plan, as well as the City's now-defunct natural gas ban on new buildings. Upcoming policy initiatives include the Berkeley Building Electrification and Just Transition Pilot Program, Measure GG, the Bay Area Air Quality Management District's regional ban on new NOx-emitting appliances, and more.

What is your view on the Climate Action Plan and these strategies? What are the most important things we need to do to address greenhouse gas emissions?

I am very much in favor of the Climate Action Plan and am extremely proud that Berkeley has already been a pioneer and example for how other cities can reduce GHG emissions. I am strongly in favor of all the initiatives mentioned above except for Measure GG. Even though I support the goals of GG, I have issues with its proposed implementation strategies.

Please discuss your ideas and priorities around how Berkeley can reduce emissions from transportation and buildings, and how we should align the climate transition with our other goals as a city.

The best way Berkeley can reduce GHG emissions is through development. Both by adding denser housing in areas well served by transit to reduce our population's reliance on cars for transportation as well as making more efficient use of energy used for heating, cooling, etc. I support the push towards building electrification efforts and believe this should be a key strategy moving forward.

The second most important way to reduce GHG emissions is to change our transportation infrastructure to increase walkability and make it easier to get around using bicycles and other forms of micromobility, and to support the adoption of EVs throughout the city. The city should convert its own fleet of automobiles to EV.

3. In your opinion, what was the most important City Council vote on Berkeley's housing crisis in the past four years? Briefly describe the issue, what you think of the Council's decision, and what you would have done had you been on the Council. For incumbents, please describe why you voted the way you did, and what you think now about that vote.

Because I believe so strongly in upzoning to increase density, I think that the vote to upzone the student area of campus from late last year was the most important. This area is especially in need of greater density, and is already extremely well geared for a car free lifestyle. I would have voted yes on this had I been on Council, and I plan to vote yes on all initiatives that upzone parts of the city, provided they don't create any significant threats to public safety.

4. In your opinion, what was the most important climate or environmental issue faced by the Berkeley City Council in the last four years? Briefly describe the issue, what you think of the Council's decision, and what you would have done had you been on the Council. For incumbents, please describe why you voted the way you did, and what you think now about that vote.

I am extremely proud of our accomplishments as a city to offer 100% renewable energy to all of our citizens through East Bay Community Energy. While this effort began long before the last 4 years, there have been recent changes made that resulted in universal adoption of this program. I would have voted yes on any proposal that promoted greater access and higher participation in the EBCE program.

5. To achieve its RHNA goals, Berkeley must continue to build homes for all income levels. These new residents will need to travel within Berkeley. Greenhouse gas (GHG) emissions from transportation comprise roughly 60% of total emissions in Berkeley.

How would you ensure that Berkeley continues to reduce GHG emissions while adding new homes?

The biggest remaining battle in reducing GHG emissions in new construction is the electrification ordinance, which I supported strongly and celebrated the passing of. It's unfortunate that it was struck down by the courts but I know there are efforts currently underway to make a second attempt that should pass legal muster. I could not be more supportive of these efforts and plan to vote yes when it comes before Council.

Regarding emissions from travel, I have already outlined my priorities in earlier answers, but essentially I support supporting the adoption of EVs by creating public and paving the way for private charging infrastructure, focusing building efforts on areas of the city that are well served by public transit, and improving pedestrian and bicycle safety to promote these modes of transportation.

6. Walking and biking presents opportunities to help Berkeley residents reduce their GHG emissions, but safety concerns can be a major deterrent. Of the two competing street paving measures on the ballot this November, one of the major differences between the two is the approach to funding safety improvements for walking and biking.

Measure EE would provide safety funding only for traffic calming on bicycle boulevards and major pedestrian projects identified in the Pedestrian Plan. Measure FF would provide funding to implement safety measures throughout the city, based on existing plans.

What is your perspective on how we should address pedestrian and cyclist safety on our streets? What is your perspective on these two measures?

I would strongly prefer either one to nothing passing, because this is an essential need at this moment in our city's development. I am planning to support EE and not FF for the simple reason that I prefer its focus on improving Bicycle Boulevards. The BB system is a wonderful plan that hasn't been implemented with enough thoughtfulness and attention. I would like to see our BBs prioritized for paving, drastically increase traffic calming measures such that only extremely local traffic was present at any time, and improving the safety of crossings of major streets. This would create a lovely, desirable network allowing access to anywhere in the city (I would add Rose St. as a BB, as was laid out in the initial plan), at a reduced cost and with less disruption to current traffic patterns. I am specifically skeptical of the cycletracks that are emphasized in the FF plan, as I do not believe they increase safety and have often been poorly implemented.

7. Berkeley has a long history of using zoning, restrictive covenants and redlining to achieve racial and economic segregation. This history continues to shape Berkeley today.

Recent research by the Turner Center at UC Berkeley suggests that inclusionary zoning requirements, which mandate on-site restricted affordable housing in new developments, may have the effect of reducing overall housing construction, including the production of affordable units. However, on-site affordable housing can also be an effective tool for desegregating neighborhoods.

What is your perspective on how Berkeley should use inclusionary zoning requirements, versus other affordable housing development options (such as in-lieu fees)?

I am happy with the current flexibility between requiring in lieu fees or inclusionary affordable housing. It's very important that new market rate development provides additional housing available to lower income residents, but additional restrictions on that might deter the housing from being built in the first place, which would be a lose - lose. In lieu payments can be used extremely effectively and I think they are a perfectly acceptable way to promote affordable housing.

8. Many of the highest income neighborhoods in Berkeley are also in the Hillside Overlay, portions of which are in the California Very High Fire Hazard Severity Zone (CalFire VHFHSZ). How should we balance fire risk with affirmatively furthering fair housing?

I believe I outlined my position on this topic above, but in short, I feel that adding additional density in these zones creates too large a public safety risk for me to feel comfortable supporting it. It is extremely unfortunate that this stance also sustains our shameful historic

inequity of development patterns, but I ultimately have to weigh the safety of the public I'm asking to represent higher than an ideal of perfect equity.